Name: **Roll No:** **Batch:**

I. Pre-reading: Do you agree or disagree with the statements given below? Give reasons.

1. A person's identity is closely connected to where they live.
2. Understanding family history helps people understand themselves better.
3. Borders, whether created or shifted, can profoundly influence people's lives and futures.
4. People who have never experienced Partition can still be affected by it.

II. Read the following excerpt from '*In the Language of Remembering - The Inheritance of Partition'*. As you read:

- **underline the words and phrases that you find interesting.**
- **highlight sentences that reveal something about identity**.

1- Beginning

My first question is always about the beginning. *When did you first hear about your family's story of Partition? How old were you, and did you understand what it meant?* The answers, naturally, vary. Some stories emerge when family members get together and reminisce about the past or speak about the economic and social losses that occurred. Some stories are exhumed because of objects such as heirlooms carried across during Partition. Some stories begin with semantics - the word refugee, the use of language never passed down, the mention of a birthplace now on the other side. Some stories begin with the concept of home and belonging - *where are we from*, many of my interviews have asked their families, *where is our ancestral village?*

Therefore, in this book, the term beginning is not defined as the origin of memory but, rather, the inheritance of memory. A story begins when a memory of Partition is bequeathed from one person to another, or one generation to the next.

…I have journeyed through many beginnings- that moment when someone first learns that their family was affected by Partition, the moment of transference, of transmission. When personal relationship with a collective history is established…. In any case there is no one beginning, and no means to predict its arrival. It is different for every person and is often quite removed from the actual sites of Partition.

“So, when did you first talk to someone about Partition?” I asked my grandmother Bhag Malhotra, one evening… “When you asked about it all those years ago,” she answers nonchalantly.

My mouth drops open slightly. Surely that couldn’t be the case. Surely, sixty-six years couldn’t have passed before she began talking candidly about possibly the most devastating event of her life...I try to enquire further, but this is not a topic she wants to discuss, so I veer towards the second generation, her children.

“No, never. What would they know about what Partition was?” she scoffs, “They were so young.”

“But did they never ask where you were from even when they were older?”

“Beta,” she begins, almost frustrated with the line of questioning. She cannot understand why I want to know these thigs. “I had work to do. There was no choice in the matter. I used to wake up at 4.00 am wash and dry clothes, do any sewing that needed to be done. Then I would get the children ready for school, make all our lunches, then your grandfather and I would get ready and leave for work... Then in the evening I’d have to prepare dinner, make sure things were laid out for the next day, check the children’s homework. And that’s how it continued. There was no time for questions, for reminiscing or remembering. Where was the leisure? There was no time for children, even. They never asked and we never told them. How could I speak to the children about…” she pauses before uttering “…Partition?”

“But if they had asked, would you have told them?”

“*Zaroor*, why not. Just like you ask questions, if they had asked, I would have told them. Maybe they did ask once they were older. But Partition was not a subject spoken about in our home,” she says with finality.

Later that night, I think about the difficulty in having conversations about partition, how the very mention of the word can lead to extreme reactions, ranging from deep nostalgia to acute bitterness. By all accounts it is a fragile, often uncharted territory…

‘Do you think certain habits or qualities of your parents have been shaped by Partition?’ I am tempted to contribute my own observations on the subject, but I am interested in what she (my mother) may say.

‘Yes, for sure. My mother never trusts anyone, from the outset. And it definitely comes from the fact that just before and during Partition her family could rely on no one but themselves to survive. You must know this, that after her father passed away, her mother was cheated out of family property, had to leave the ancestral home, and had to begin working to support her children. My mother once said this to me too, that if one’s whole childhood has been shaped by mistrust, it becomes your default. And the second is her tendency to hoard things, just in case she may need them later. This stems purely from lack of resources, because when you don’t have enough, you have the propensity to hoard what you have, not let go of even the smallest thing- be it food or extra cloth or wool, or even buttons. Even if you are not in that position anymore, the habit has become your nature so that you cannot throw away anything… If I tell her to throw them, she always responds with, you can throw them when I die.”

“When you understood the sheer scale of Partition, I advance towards a more serious question, ‘how many people if affected, how many families it tore apart, the violence, the trauma, the immensity of loss on both sides, how did it make you feel to know that both your parents had witnessed it?”

“I felt horrible,’ she answers in a small voice, ‘horrible for having judged them growing up. They inherited habits they could not have helped.”

‘Did you think,’ I ask my grandmother, ‘that subsequent generations of your family would ever be interested in knowing about your experiences of Partition?’

I am not surprised when she answers very quickly in the negative. ‘I didn’t think the event would matter after it happened, or that anyone would put it in books or interview the people who had lived through it. I couldn’t even imagine any of our children or grandchildren asking, thinking, or writing about Partition… We never wanted to burden them with our memories. We wanted the sadness to end with us, to remain in our generation, to never be passed down.”

(Excerpt from pages 1-21)

In the Language of Remembering - The Inheritance of Partition. Anchal Malhotra. Harper Collins. 2022.

III. Main Ideas and Supporting Details

1. Which statement best captures the author's central argument?

a) Memories of historical events continue to shape the identities of later generations, even when those memories remain unspoken.
b) Partition caused families to migrate and lose their homes, changing where many people eventually settled.
c) Family conversations are important because they help younger generations understand historical events.
d) Although Partition was a historical event, people remember and respond to it in different ways depending on their personal experiences.

2. Read the statements below and write M for the main idea, S for supporting details

1. Family memories can shape identity across generations.
2. Some stories begin with heirlooms carried across the border.
3. The grandmother woke at 4.00 a.m. every day to work.
4. Historical events continue to influence later generations.
5. The author's grandmother inherited habits of mistrust and hoarding.
6. Silence can become part of a family's identity.

IV: Critical Reading

1. Why do you think the author wrote this extract?

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2. Identify 3 themes that appear in the extract.

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3. “We wanted the sadness to end with us, to remain in our generation, to never be passed down.” What does this final line reveal about the emotional burden carried by survivors of Partition?

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4. Partition not only divided the land, but it also transformed identities. Discuss.

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5. Analyse how the experiences of Partition influenced the identities of the first-generation survivors differently from their children and grandchildren.

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6. Is identity determined more by the birthplace, culture, language or personal experience? What does the extract suggest about the relationship between memory and identity?

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V: Personal Response

1. Can listening to personal stories help us understand history better than reading facts alone? Should personal stories and photographs be considered as important as official historical records? Why?

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2. What is the one question that you would want to ask the grandmother?

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3. List three items a family might carry during migration and explain why each is important.

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VI: Although all four texts in this module focus on identity, each writer examines it from a different perspective. Complete the table below by listing what shapes identity in each text (e.g., family, language, place, memory, society, history). Use key ideas from the texts rather than copying sentences.

Text	**What shapes identity in this text?**
My Name	
Identity Puzzle	
I Belong There	
In the Language of Remembering	